INDIA 2026-27 EDITION · DIGITAL EDITION

The Cloud Kitchen & Tiffin Business Playbook

Start a home tiffin service or a delivery-only cloud kitchen in India — with real 2026 numbers, licences, unit economics and a 30-day launch plan.

FSSAI 2026 RULES | GST & SECTION 9(5) | SWIGGY / ZOMATO MATHS | ONDC CHANNEL | UNIT ECONOMICS | 30-DAY LAUNCH PLAN

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Verified against FSSAI, CBIC/GST and current 2026 platform data · October 2026

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Who this playbook is for, and what it will do for you

India's food-delivery habit is no longer a trend — it is the daily routine of millions of households, and the festive season sends a fresh wave of first-time operators into the business every October and November. A tiffin service or a delivery-only cloud kitchen is one of the few businesses you can start from your own kitchen, with a real path to a steady monthly income, and without the rent, staff and fit-out of a full restaurant.

It is also a business where most new operators lose money in the first six months — not because the food is bad, but because the money maths was never worked out before the first order. The commission was higher than expected, the discounts came out of their own pocket, the licences were guessed at, and the menu was too broad to be profitable. This playbook exists to stop that.

Every number, rule, fee and threshold here was checked against official or current 2026 sources before it was written: FSSAI's licensing overhaul effective 1 April 2026, the GST treatment of restaurant supplies, the real commission and fee structure on Swiggy and Zomato, and the lower-commission ONDC route. Where sources disagree, the book says so and gives you the range. Nothing here is a promise of income — it is a working manual for making the decision, setting the price, doing the paperwork, and running the first 90 days properly.

How to use this book

Read Parts 1 to 3 first, even if you are impatient to start. The model you choose and the unit economics you set decide whether the business works before you spend a rupee.

Part 4 (licences) is a checklist — work through it in order. FSSAI is the hard blocker; nothing else, including a Swiggy or Zomato listing, moves without it.

Parts 5 to 7 are the operating manual. Part 8 is your 30-day launch grid. Part 9 is the fill-in worksheet pack you will use every week.

Part 10 is the honest section: the mistakes that kill Indian kitchens, and 20 straight answers to the questions every new operator asks.

Plain-language note: this book explains how the rules and the numbers work as of October 2026. It is not legal, tax or financial advice, and fees, commission rates and thresholds change. Before you register, list or sign a platform agreement, confirm the current position with FSSAI (foscos.fssai.gov.in), the GST portal, your local municipal body and your own chartered accountant.

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All amounts are in Indian rupees (Rs.) and are for the 2026-27 period unless stated otherwise.

PART 1

The opportunity, in 2026

Why food delivery, and why now

India's online food-delivery market has crossed three million orders a day across Swiggy and Zomato combined, and it is still growing at roughly 20% a year. That demand did not disappear after the pandemic; it became a habit. Households now order delivery for ordinary weekday meals, not only for weekends and celebrations. For a home cook or a small operator, that is the entire point: you do not need to persuade people to try delivery — they already do.

The delivery-only kitchen segment that serves this demand — the cloud kitchen — is one of the fastest-growing parts of Indian food service. Independent operators (single owners, not the big chains) make up the majority of it. And the format keeps getting cheaper to enter: a home tiffin service can start with well under Rs. 50,000, while a shared kitchen slot that lets you list on the apps can be live for a fraction of what a standalone kitchen costs.

1. India's delivery market in numbers

Different research houses size the cloud-kitchen market differently, so treat any single figure with caution. The most useful way to read the market is as a set of ranges that all point the same way — up.

Measure	What the 2026 sources say
Cloud-kitchen market size	Around US$1.39 billion in 2026, up from about US$1.24 billion in 2025; projected to reach roughly US$3.69 billion by 2034 (about 12% CAGR). Some Indian rupee-based estimates put the addressable market higher because they count the whole delivery-first food segment.
Who dominates	Independent (single-owner) operators hold the majority share — roughly 61% of the market in 2025. Multi-brand operators and shared-infrastructure platforms make up the rest.
Delivery demand	Swiggy and Zomato together serve over 3 million orders a day; online food delivery is growing 20%+ annually.
Tiffin / meal-subscription demand	India's tiffin-service segment is growing at roughly 15-20% a year, driven by working professionals, students, migrants and PG residents.
Where it is growing fastest	Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities, where cloud-kitchen adoption is rising at 40-60% a year and rents and competition are both lower than in the metros.
Geographic concentration	South India leads, followed by Delhi NCR, Mumbai, Hyderabad, Bengaluru and Chennai.

The one-line takeaway

The market is big, growing, and still majority-owned by small independent operators. You are not fighting the chains for the whole market — you are serving one neighbourhood, one campus or one office cluster, and that niche is enough to build a steady income.

2. Why the festive season is the best launch window

The stretch from Navratri and Dussehra through Dhanteras and Diwali (Dhanteras falls on 6 November and Diwali on 8 November in 2026) is the single biggest spending and hosting window of the Indian year. Two things happen that matter to a new food operator:

- Households are busier and cook less. Between cleaning, shopping, hosting and travel, home cooking drops and food delivery and tiffin orders rise.
- Corporate and office catering picks up. Festive gifting, team lunches and Diwali-week office meals create one-off bulk orders that a home kitchen can serve profitably.
- Rents and slots open up. Many small commercial kitchens change hands around the festive season, and shared-kitchen operators run onboarding drives — meaning a better choice of slot and, sometimes, a waiver on setup fees.

If you are reading this in October or early November, you are not late — you are at the start of the season. If you are reading it later, ignore the festival angle and use the rest of the book exactly as written: the model choice, the maths, the licences and the launch plan do not depend on the calendar.

3. The three ways in — and who each one suits

Almost every Indian food business you can start from home is one of three shapes. Pick the one that matches your money, your space and your appetite for paperwork — not the one that sounds most impressive.

	Home tiffin subscription	Shared / cloud kitchen slot	Standalone cloud kitchen
Typical startup cost	Rs. 10,000 – Rs. 50,000	Rs. 1.5 – 6 lakh	Rs. 3 – 15 lakh (metro standalone can reach Rs. 12-15 lakh)
Where you cook	Your own home kitchen	A rented slot in a shared commercial kitchen	Your own rented commercial kitchen
Who your customer is	Regulars on a monthly meal plan (students, offices, bachelors, PGs)	App customers in your delivery radius, plus regulars	App customers, virtual brands, plus direct orders
Main sales channel	WhatsApp, word of mouth, local groups	Swiggy / Zomato / ONDC, plus WhatsApp	Swiggy / Zomato / ONDC, plus your own website
Biggest advantage	Lowest cost, recurring income, no commission	Cheapest route to the apps; lower risk than standalone	Full control of menu, brand and capacity; can run multiple brands
Biggest risk	Capped by how many meals you can cook and deliver alone	Slot rent and commission eat into thin margins	High fixed rent and capex before you have customers
Time to first rupee	Days to a couple of weeks	2 – 4 weeks	1 – 2 months
Best if you…	…want to test the idea with very little money and keep your day job	…want app reach without a big lease	…are committing full-time and want to build a brand

A word of caution before you pick

The two mistakes that sink beginners are (1) starting with the most expensive model, and (2) copying a big brand's menu. Start with the smallest model that can prove someone will pay for your food, then reinvest. You can always upgrade from a home tiffin to a cloud kitchen; you cannot easily un-sign a Rs. 60,000-a-month lease.

PART 2

Choose your model

Three shapes, one decision

This part takes each model apart — what it really costs, how it earns, and where it breaks. Read all three before you choose; the comparison is where the decision actually gets made.

4. Model A: The home tiffin subscription

A tiffin service is a subscription kitchen: customers pay monthly (or weekly) for a set number of meals, usually lunch, dinner, or both. You cook from home, pack in tiffin carriers or sealed containers, and deliver on a fixed route at a fixed time. There is no commission, no app, and no lease — which is exactly why the margins are the best of the three models.

The honest numbers

- Startup: about Rs. 10,000 – Rs. 50,000 for extra vessels, tiffin boxes, insulated delivery bags, an extra burner, first-stock groceries, packaging and local marketing. Many operators start closer to Rs. 5,000 – Rs. 20,000 and grow slowly.
- Pricing: a typical metro meal lands around Rs. 70 – Rs. 120. Monthly plans commonly sit at Rs. 2,500 – Rs. 4,000 for one meal a day, and higher for lunch plus dinner.
- Margins: gross margin is often 40-50% per meal (food cost is roughly half the price); after packaging, delivery and overheads, net is commonly in the 25-35% band.
- Break-even: with 25-30 regular customers, a home kitchen can cover its costs in as little as two to three months.

A worked example you can trust

Take 30 customers on a Rs. 3,000-a-month lunch plan. Monthly revenue is Rs. 90,000. Food cost runs about Rs. 40,000 – 45,000, packaging about Rs. 5,000, delivery about Rs. 10,000 – 15,000, and other expenses a few thousand more. That leaves a net profit in the region of Rs. 20,000 – 30,000 a month from a home kitchen — real money, earned without a lease and without paying a rupee of app commission. Scale to 50-100 customers and the same maths can produce Rs. 50,000 – 1,00,000 a month, though you will need help.

Where the home model breaks

Capacity. One cook, one kitchen and one delivery route cap how many meals you can serve. The moment quality or punctuality slips, subscriptions cancel — and a subscription business loses a whole month of revenue when one customer leaves, not one order.

Menu monotony. A fixed monthly plan needs a 7-day rotation that is genuinely different, or customers churn by week three.

No-shows and holidays. Build pause / skip rules into the plan in writing, or disputes over 'missed days' will eat your goodwill.

5. Model B: The shared / cloud kitchen slot

A shared kitchen (sometimes called a cloud-kitchen slot or kitchen pod) is a commercial kitchen that rents you a station — a burner, prep space and storage — inside a facility run by someone else. You get the licences, hygiene standards and equipment you would otherwise have to fund yourself, and, crucially, you get the address and compliance records that let you list on the food apps. This is the

cheapest realistic route to Swiggy and Zomato.

- Startup: about Rs. 1.5 – 6 lakh, covering the slot deposit, your share of equipment, utilities buffer, packaging station and one to two months of runway. A Tier-2 shared kitchen can sometimes go live for under Rs. 3 lakh.
- What you still pay monthly: slot rent, utilities, and — if you list on the apps — commission on every order. Rent on functional back-lane space is often higher per square foot than you would expect, because you are paying for a working kitchen, not an address.
- Best for: someone who wants app reach and a professional kitchen without a long, expensive lease. It is the middle path — more reach than a home tiffin, less risk than a standalone kitchen.
- Watch for: what exactly the rent includes (gas, power, cold storage, cleaning), whether the facility's FSSAI and trade licences actually cover your activity, and how the slot handles peak-hour burner clashes with other tenants.

6. Model C: The standalone cloud kitchen

A standalone cloud kitchen is your own rented commercial kitchen with no dining room. You control everything — the menu, the brand, the equipment and the capacity — and you can run more than one virtual brand from the same space. It is also the model that requires the most money before you have a single customer.

- Startup: roughly Rs. 3 – 15 lakh depending on city and format. A shared-kitchen setup in a Tier-2 city can go live under Rs. 3 lakh; a standalone metro kitchen running multiple brands can reach Rs. 12 – 15 lakh.
- Typical line items: kitchen space (rent plus deposit), equipment (burners, chimney, fridge, storage), interior and basic fit-out, licences, first stock of raw material, packaging, branding and photography, and initial marketing.
- Best for: a full-time operator who wants to build a brand and can fund the setup without borrowing at credit-card rates.
- The trap: signing a big lease and buying full equipment before you have proven that your food sells in your pincode. Most standalone kitchens that fail in month four fail on cash, not on cooking.

The rule that saves first-timers

Prove demand before you commit capital. Run a home tiffin or a shared-kitchen slot for 60-90 days first. If your menu sells and your reviews hold above 4.2, you will have both the proof and the cash flow to justify a standalone kitchen — and you will know your real costs instead of guessing them.

7. One brand or several? The virtual-brand decision

A virtual brand is a menu that exists only on the apps — a name, a cuisine and a set of dishes — cooked from the same kitchen as your main brand. Multi-brand operators run three or four of them from one kitchen because each brand hits a different search on the app (biryani, rolls, pizza, desserts), so the same square footage and the same equipment generate more orders.

	Single brand	Multiple virtual brands
What it is	One menu, one name	3-4 menus, each with its own name, from one kitchen
Why do it	Simpler to run and market; lower food wastage	More searches captured; higher revenue per square foot; spreads fixed costs

	Single brand	Multiple virtual brands
The cost	Lower revenue ceiling	More prep complexity, more stock, more packaging SKUs, risk of quality slip
When to add more	Start here	Only after the first brand is profitable and rated above 4.2, and you have the staff to run it

For a first-time operator, the honest advice is to start with one brand and one focused cuisine. Add a second virtual brand only when the first one is genuinely working — otherwise you spread a thin margin across two half-built businesses.

PART 3

The money maths

Where kitchens are actually won and lost

This is the most important part of the book. If you read nothing else, read this. Almost every failed Indian cloud kitchen had food people liked — it died because the owner never worked out what was left after the commission, the discount, the packaging and the rent.

8. What it costs to start, by model

The tables below are planning bands, not quotes. Treat the top of each range as what you will spend if you are not careful, and the bottom as what a disciplined, second-hand-equipment, home-first start can cost.

Home tiffin service — line items

Item	Approx. cost
FSSAI Basic Registration	Rs. 100 / year (plus a small service charge if you use an agent)
Extra vessels and cookware	Rs. 3,000 – 10,000
Tiffin boxes / containers (20-30 pieces)	Rs. 2,000 – 8,000
Insulated delivery bags	Rs. 1,500 – 3,000
Additional gas stove / burner	Rs. 1,500 – 4,000
First-stock groceries (about a week)	Rs. 3,000 – 8,000
Packaging, labels, branding	Rs. 500 – 2,000
Local marketing (flyers, printing)	Rs. 1,000 – 5,000
Delivery (self, initially)	Rs. 0 – 10,000
Total	About Rs. 10,000 – 50,000

Shared kitchen slot — line items

Item	Approx. cost
Slot deposit + first month rent	Rs. 30,000 – 1,00,000
Your share of equipment / initial fit-out	Rs. 50,000 – 2,00,000
Licences and registrations	Rs. 5,000 – 25,000
POS / billing / aggregator onboarding tools	Rs. 10,000 – 30,000
Initial raw material and packaging	Rs. 30,000 – 75,000
Branding, photography and listings	Rs. 20,000 – 60,000
Working capital buffer (15-30 days)	Rs. 25,000 – 75,000
Total	About Rs. 1.5 – 6 lakh

Standalone cloud kitchen — line items

Item	Shared / small setup	Standalone kitchen
Kitchen space (rent + deposit)	Rs. 20,000 – 40,000 / month	Rs. 60,000 – 1,00,000 / month
Equipment (burners, chimney, fridge, storage)	Rs. 1,00,000 – 2,00,000	Rs. 2,50,000 – 5,00,000
Interior / basic fit-out	Rs. 30,000 – 1,50,000	Rs. 1,50,000 – 4,00,000
Licences (FSSAI, GST, trade, fire, etc.)	Rs. 5,000 – 15,000	Rs. 10,000 – 25,000
Tech (POS, billing, onboarding)	Rs. 10,000 – 25,000	Rs. 25,000 – 50,000
Initial raw material + packaging	Rs. 40,000 – 75,000	Rs. 75,000 – 1,50,000
Branding, photography, listings, ads	Rs. 20,000 – 50,000	Rs. 50,000 – 1,00,000
Total (one-time)	About Rs. 3 – 5 lakh	About Rs. 10 – 15 lakh

Keep 15-30 days of ingredient capital on hand before subscription or platform money settles reliably. Running out of working capital — not bad food — is the most common reason a promising kitchen closes.

9. The unit economics of one order

Unit economics means: on a single order, what is left for you? It is the only number that matters, because no amount of volume fixes a dish that loses money. Here is a worked example on a Rs. 250 average order value (AOV), using figures Indian operators commonly report in 2026.

Line	Amount	Note
Customer pays (menu price)	**Rs. 250**	Your listed price on the app
Less: platform commission (~25%)	**– Rs. 62.50**	Ranges 18-28%; single-outlet kitchens commonly land at 25-27%
Less: GST on commission (18% of commission)	**– Rs. 11.25**	Unrecoverable if you are on the 5% no-ITC scheme
Less: payment / collection fee (~2%)	**– Rs. 5.00**	On prepaid orders
Your payout before food cost	**Rs. 171.25**	What reaches your settlement
Less: food cost (about 32%)	**– Rs. 80.00**	Raw material for the dish
Less: packaging	**– Rs. 15.00**	Container, seal, label, cutlery, bag
Contribution per order	**Rs. 76.25**	Before rent, staff, gas, ads and any discount you funded

Notice what is not yet subtracted: rent, staff wages, electricity and gas, marketing or ad spend, and — the big one — any discount you agreed to fund. A 'flat 40% off' campaign that you co-fund can wipe out the entire Rs. 76 contribution on a Rs. 250 order. This is why funded discounts, not commission, are the largest controllable leak in the business.

The two numbers to remember

Aggregator commission sits in a 15-30% band, most often 18-25%, charged on the net order value (after your discount). On top sit 18% GST on the commission, a payment fee of about 2%, and the discounts you fund.

Platform fee is not your cost. The Rs. 17.58-per-order fee that Swiggy and Zomato raised in March 2026 is charged to the diner, not deducted from your settlement. If your payout statement shows it as a deduction, question it. It still matters indirectly: a higher customer bill can reduce order volume.

10. What actually leaves your account on an app order

The headline commission is only the start. Here is the full list of deductions and charges that hit an Indian app order in 2026, and who really pays each one.

Charge	Typical 2026 figure	Who pays / what to know
Base commission	Zomato 18-28%; Swiggy 17-25%; effective all-in often 25-35%	Deducted from your settlement. Negotiable with scale (roughly 10+ outlets can reach 18-22%).
GST on commission	18% of the commission	You pay it; not recoverable on the 5% no-ITC restaurant scheme.
Payment / collection fee	About 1.8 – 2% on prepaid orders	Deducted from settlement.
Platform fee	Rs. 17.58 per order (incl. GST), after the March 2026 hike	Charged to the customer, not deducted from you.
Funded discounts	Whatever campaign you opt into	Funded by you. The single biggest controllable cost.
TDS (section 194-O)	0.1%	Withheld and adjustable against your income tax.
Long-distance / other fees	Varies; e.g. up to about Rs. 40 beyond 6 km on some contracts	Sits disproportionately on cloud kitchens, whose radius is often in the 4-6 km band.

A Zomato spokesperson has stated a cap of 30% on the total payable by a restaurant 'including all components' — the most defensible ceiling available in public reporting. But neither platform publishes an official rate card: your commission is set per outlet by contract, and your partner agreement and monthly settlement statement are the only binding source. Read your own agreement; the range in this book is a benchmark, not a quote.

Context worth knowing: the restaurant body NRAI took the platform-fee hike to the Competition Commission of India, which closed the platform-fee complaint in July 2026 without finding a prima facie case. Around the same period, reporting indicated Zomato removed its price-parity requirement (the clause that stopped restaurants pricing lower on their own channel), and a zero-commission competitor, Rapido Ownly, entered the market. The direction of travel — more channels, more options — is good news for operators, but the standard commission is not about to disappear.

11. Pricing to survive the commission

If you list on an app, your delivery price cannot be your dine-in price. The commission, GST, payment fee and any discount you fund come out of the order, so successful operators price their delivery menu about 15-25% higher than their normal prices to absorb the take. Do this at the menu level, not

by quietly shrinking portions — customers notice portion cuts and punish them in ratings.

The worked rule: if a dish costs you Rs. 100 to make and pack, and the app takes roughly a third, then to keep a real profit you must list it at about Rs. 200 – 230 on the app — not Rs. 150. Anything cheaper and you are paying the platform to cook for someone else. The dish-costing sheet in Part 9 makes this calculation for every item on your menu before you publish it.

Three pricing habits that protect margin

Know your cost per dish — ingredients plus packing plus gas plus a share of labour — before you set a single price.

Never list a dish that is unprofitable after a 30-35% deduction. Fix the price or remove the dish.

Raise order value with combos, add-ons and a drink, so fixed costs like the payment fee are spread across a bigger bill.

12. Break-even: orders a day, and how many months

A well-run cloud kitchen usually needs 40-60 orders a day at an average order value of Rs. 250-350 to break even, and typically takes 6-12 months to get there. Kitchens that never cross about 30 orders a day for a sustained period are the ones that default on rent and close. For a Rs. 15 lakh outlet, break-even commonly lands around 14-20 months at roughly Rs. 6 lakh of monthly revenue — which is why starting small and proving demand first is not timidity, it is arithmetic.

Metric	Healthy benchmark (2026)
Food cost (raw material)	28 – 35% of revenue
Aggregator commission (blended)	25 – 32% of revenue
Labour	15 – 18% of revenue
Rent	8 – 12% of revenue
Packaging + disposables	About 2 – 5% of revenue
Marketing / ads	3 – 6% of revenue
Store-level net margin (optimised)	About 8 – 14%
Break-even orders per day	40 – 60 at AOV Rs. 250 – 350

The single biggest lever on that margin is the share of orders you take through your own direct channel, because a direct order carries no commission. A kitchen with no direct channel and heavy reliance on app ads can sit at break-even; the same kitchen with even a quarter of its orders coming direct can climb several percentage points of net margin. Part 6 shows you how to build that channel.

13. The three leaks that close kitchens

1. Funded discounts. Opting into every 'flat off' campaign the app offers, without checking what you are funding, quietly turns profitable dishes into loss-leaders. Decide a discount budget and stick to it.
2. A menu that is too broad. Kitchens running 85+ items carry more stock, more wastage and slower prep. A focused menu of one or two cuisines, done well, almost always out-earns a long menu done thinly.
3. No direct ordering channel. If every order pays commission, your ceiling is fixed. A WhatsApp or website ordering link, pushed to repeat customers, is the cheapest margin you will ever buy.

Fix these three and you have removed the most common causes of early failure. Everything else in this book is about doing the basics consistently.

PART 4

Licences & compliance

The 2026 rules, in order

Compliance is not paperwork for its own sake — it is the gate that decides whether you can legally cook for money and whether any app will list you. FSSAI is the hard blocker; GST is the one that decides your tax position; the other four are local requirements that vary by city and premises. Work through this part in order.

14. FSSAI after the April 2026 overhaul

On 10 March 2026, FSSAI notified the Food Safety and Standards (Licensing and Registration of Food Businesses) Amendment Regulations, 2026, and an implementation order dated 13 March 2026 raised the turnover thresholds with effect from 1 April 2026. This is the single most important change for small food businesses in years, because it moved a large number of small kitchens from a State Licence down to the much simpler and cheaper Basic Registration.

Category	Turnover band (from 1 April 2026)	Indicative annual fee
Basic Registration	Up to Rs. 1.5 crore	Rs. 100 / year
State Licence	Above Rs. 1.5 crore, up to Rs. 50 crore	About Rs. 2,000 – 5,000 / year
Central Licence	Above Rs. 50 crore	Rs. 7,500 / year

What else changed, and what did not

- Perpetual validity. Registrations and licences issued from 1 April 2026 have perpetual validity — they stay valid unless suspended, cancelled or surrendered. There is no renewal cycle any more.
- But the annual fee still applies. If you do not pay the annual fee, the licence is treated as suspended and you cannot legally carry on the business. Perpetual validity removed the renewal application, not the yearly fee.
- No pre-inspection and instant registration for small businesses. The reform specifically aimed to cut paperwork, fees and inspection for micro and small operators.
- Deemed registration for street vendors already registered under the Street Vendors Act, 2014 — they no longer need a second registration. (Not directly relevant to a cloud kitchen, but it shows the direction of the reform.)
- The Rs. 1.5 crore figure is a category threshold, not an exemption. Every food business operator, whatever its turnover, must hold a valid FSSAI registration or licence.

How to apply

1. Go to the official FoSCoS portal at foscos.fssai.gov.in. The old FLRS portal is closed.
2. Choose the kind of business that matches a delivery-only kitchen or a home tiffin service, and the correct tier for your expected turnover.
3. Upload the required documents, pay the fee, and get your 14-digit FSSAI number. Basic Registration is designed to be quick; a State Licence can take longer.
4. Display the 14-digit number on packaging, invoices and your app listings. It must be valid and visible.

One nuance that catches people out

Aggregators sometimes insist on a State Licence rather than Basic Registration for kitchens handling meat, poultry, seafood or dairy-heavy menus, treating those as higher-risk categories regardless of turnover. Confirm the tier your menu requires with the platform's onboarding team before you apply, so you file once and file correctly.

15. GST: the 5% rule, section 9(5) and section 24(ix)

GST for food businesses looks complicated but rests on three simple rules. Get these right and the rest follows.

Rule 1 — restaurant service is 5%, without input tax credit

Most restaurants, including cloud kitchens and delivery-only kitchens, are treated as 'restaurant service' and taxed at 5% (2.5% CGST + 2.5% SGST), with no input tax credit available on rent, raw materials, packaging or equipment. The 18% rate with ITC applies only to a restaurant inside 'specified premises' — broadly a hotel where a room was supplied above Rs. 7,500 a night. Air-conditioning no longer changes the rate. These rates were retained under the GST 2.0 changes effective 22 September 2025.

Rule 2 — on app orders, the platform pays the GST (section 9(5))

Since 1 January 2022, food-delivery platforms are treated as the supplier of the restaurant service under section 9(5) of the CGST Act. In plain terms: when a customer orders Rs. 500 of food through Swiggy or Zomato, the platform collects the 5% GST (Rs. 25) and pays it to the government. You do not separately charge or pay that 5% on those orders — but you still report them in your returns, and you must count them in your aggregate turnover.

Rule 3 — listing on an app makes GST registration compulsory (section 24(ix))

The general GST registration threshold is Rs. 20 lakh (Rs. 10 lakh in special-category states). But the widely held reading among tax practitioners is that once you supply restaurant service through an e-commerce operator, GST registration becomes mandatory regardless of turnover, because section 24(ix) compels registration for supplies through an operator and the notified section 9(5) restaurant supplies are excluded from the usual threshold exemption. The practical rule for a cloud kitchen is therefore: if you list on Swiggy or Zomato, assume you must register for GST from day one, and get it right with your accountant.

GST question	The 2026 position
Rate on food	5%, without input tax credit (standalone restaurants, takeaway, cloud kitchens)
Rate on a hotel restaurant (room above Rs. 7,500/night)	18%, with ITC
Who pays GST on app orders	The platform, under section 9(5)
GST on the platform's commission	18% on the commission; you pay it and cannot recover it on the 5% no-ITC scheme
Do you need to register if you list on an app?	Widely held to be yes, regardless of turnover, under section 24(ix)
Composition scheme	5% flat, but restricted — you generally cannot sell through an operator that collects TCS; check with your adviser before opting in

GST question	The 2026 position
Returns	Report platform orders in GSTR-1; file GSTR-3B; keep platform-wise reconciliation

16. The other four registrations

Beyond FSSAI and GST, most cloud kitchens need some or all of the following, depending on the city and the premises. These are local requirements — confirm the exact list with your municipal corporation.

Registration	Typical cost	What it is
Trade licence	Rs. 5,000 – 15,000 / year	From your municipal corporation (e.g. BMC, BBMP, MCD, GHMC, GCC). Tied to premises size and category.
Shops & Establishment registration	Rs. 500 – 2,000	A state-level requirement if you employ staff.
Fire safety NOC	Rs. 2,000 – 5,000 (plus 2-4 weeks)	Needed where you use commercial gas cylinders or heavy electricals.
Health trade licence	Varies	Applies in some states only (for example West Bengal and Delhi). Check locally.

Sequencing matters. Apply for FSSAI on day one of signing your lease — it can take the longest. Apply for GST and Shops & Establishment in week two. Get the Fire NOC after your fit-out, once the gas and electrical layout is fixed.

17. Your compliance calendar and document vault

Set up one folder — physical and digital — and keep these documents current. Every one of them will be asked for at least once, most often by the apps.

- FSSAI registration or licence (14-digit number), with the business name and premises address matching everywhere.
- GST registration certificate (GSTIN), with the legal name matching your PAN and bank account.
- PAN of the proprietor or entity.
- Bank proof — a cancelled cheque or bank statement in the business name.
- Owner or authorised-signatory ID for KYC.
- Rental agreement or premises proof, trade licence, Shops & Establishment, and Fire NOC where applicable.
- A simple recurring reminder to pay the FSSAI annual fee — miss it and the licence is deemed suspended.

The mismatch that delays almost everyone

The most common cause of onboarding delay is a business name or address that does not match across documents — a GST name that differs from the FSSAI registration, or a bank account in a personal name while the FSSAI is in a trade name. Align the name and address on your FSSAI, GST, PAN and bank account before you apply anywhere. It is a five-minute check that saves two weeks.

PART 5

Menu & pricing

What you sell, and what it must cost

18. The delivery-friendly menu

A delivery menu is not a restaurant menu. Food that is brilliant on a plate can be a disaster in a box after twenty minutes on a scooter. Build the menu around what travels well and stays profitable, not around what you most enjoy cooking.

What travels well

- Rice and gravy dishes that hold heat and texture — biryani, pulao, curries, dal, rajma, chole, and Indian breads that reheat well.
- Rolls, wraps, parathas and stuffed breads that survive the ride without going soggy.
- One-pot and combo meals, which also raise order value.

What travels badly

- Fried snacks and anything meant to be crisp — they steam in the box and arrive soft.
- Delicate salads and raw-garnish-heavy plates.
- Anything with a separate sauce that leaks, unless you use sealed compartments.

Keep the core menu to one or two cuisines and about 12-20 items. A tight menu means faster prep, less stock, less wastage and a lower chance of a wrong or delayed order — all of which show up in your rating and your margin.

19. Costing one dish, properly

Before a dish goes on the menu, cost it line by line. The formula is simple: add up the ingredients, the gas used to cook it, the packaging and a share of your labour, then add your target margin. If the resulting price is more than customers in your area will pay, change the dish — do not sell it at a loss.

Cost component	How to estimate it
Ingredients	Weigh and price the exact quantities in one portion (not the whole batch)
Gas / fuel	A small per-dish allowance — track it for a week and divide
Packaging	Container, seal, label, cutlery, carry bag — the real total, not just the box
Labour	A per-dish share of what you pay yourself or your cook
Subtotal = dish cost	The floor below which the dish loses money
Add target margin	30-50% for a home tiffin; enough to clear 30-35% app deduction on the app
= Selling price	Check it against what your area already pays before you publish

The worksheet in Part 9 lets you do this for every dish in one sitting. Do it once, properly, and you will never again guess whether an order made you money.

20. Tiffin pricing bands and the delivery mark-up

There are two pricing worlds in this business, and you must not confuse them. A tiffin subscription has no commission, so it is priced on food cost plus a fair margin. An app order carries a heavy take, so it is priced higher to absorb that take.

Channel	Typical price	Pricing logic
Tiffin subscription (per meal)	Rs. 70 – 120	Food cost plus 40-50% gross margin; no commission
Tiffin monthly plan	Rs. 2,500 – 4,000 (one meal a day)	Volume discount for a committed customer; steady, predictable income
App / delivery menu	About 15-25% higher than your normal price	To absorb 25-35% commission, GST on commission and payment fees
Combos and add-ons	Slightly above the sum of parts	Raises order value so fixed fees are spread across a bigger bill

Keep your subscription customers on the subscription price, and your app customers on the app price. If you ever want to reward regulars, do it through your own direct channel — not by undercutting yourself on an app where every rupee of discount comes straight out of your pocket.

21. Packaging that protects margin and ratings

Packaging is not a detail. Leaking gravies and soggy boxes produce one-star reviews, and a rating that slips below about 4.0 can cut your app visibility and your orders sharply. Spend on packaging where it prevents complaints, and keep it cheap where it does not.

- Use leak-resistant, sealed containers for gravies and curries, and compartment boxes for combo meals.
- Insulate: an insulated bag on the delivery route keeps food hot, which is the single biggest driver of repeat orders.
- Label clearly: dish name, veg/non-veg mark, and your FSSAI number. Mis-labelled or missing veg/non-veg marks cause avoidable complaints and can breach listing rules.
- Budget packaging as a real line item — it is typically about 2-5% of revenue and, on low-value orders, a bigger share than the commission.

PART 6

Getting customers

From zero to a full order book

A kitchen with no customers is an expensive hobby. This part gives you a sequence: prove the food with the cheapest channel first, then add the apps, then add the low-commission network, and finally build the channel that pays you the most — your own.

22. The WhatsApp engine: your first 30 customers

Before you spend on anything, get your first 30 paying customers the way home food businesses have always done it — locally, on WhatsApp, through people who already know you. This proves the food and funds the next step, with almost no marketing cost.

1. Pick a dense route. Choose one apartment complex, one PG cluster, one office block or one hostel, not the whole city. Density is what makes delivery viable and word of mouth fast.
2. Publish a simple weekly menu. A 7-day rotation, one image, clear prices, and a monthly plan price. Send it to local groups, your own contacts and WhatsApp status.
3. Offer a trial meal. A discounted first meal converts far better than a discounted first month, and it lets people taste before committing.
4. Ask for referrals inside the cluster. One happy customer in a PG usually brings three more from the same building.
5. Write down pause and skip rules. Say clearly how a customer pauses a plan and what happens on holidays. This prevents the disputes that sour subscription businesses.

Target: 25-30 regulars in 30-45 days

At 30 customers on a Rs. 3,000-a-month plan, you are running about Rs. 90,000 of monthly revenue with no commission. That is the moment you have earned the right to spend money on the next channel.

23. Getting listed on Swiggy and Zomato

The apps bring reach you cannot build alone, but they bring commission with it. Onboarding is mostly a documentation exercise — the decisions that matter (pricing, menu scope, delivery radius) are made during onboarding and are harder to change later, so go in having thought about them.

The document set both platforms ask for

- A valid FSSAI registration or licence, with the business name and premises matching exactly.
- GST registration (generally required to supply through an e-commerce operator).
- PAN of the business or proprietor.
- A cancelled cheque or bank details in the business name for payouts.
- Owner or authorised-signatory ID for KYC.
- Kitchen and dish photographs, and a launch-ready menu with prices.

The steps

1. Register your interest on the official partner portals — Swiggy at partner.swiggy.com, Zomato at partner.zomato.com / zomato.com/business. Register with both; the marginal effort of the second

is small.

2. Submit your documents and wait for verification — this is where most of the time goes.
3. Agree commercial terms, including your commission rate. This is negotiable and worth treating as such.
4. Build your menu with categories, descriptions, veg/non-veg tags and photographs.
5. Set your delivery radius (5 km is a common sweet spot) and your operating hours.
6. Complete any onboarding call or training, then go live.

Typical timelines once documents are complete: about 3-7 working days for Swiggy and 2-5 business days for Zomato, assuming no mismatch flags. Register with both — most operators find their order split between the two is not what they expected.

24. ONDC: the low-commission channel

ONDC — the Open Network for Digital Commerce — is a government-backed open protocol that unbundles delivery into three separate roles: a buyer app brings the customer, a seller app represents you, and a logistics provider delivers. Because these roles compete independently instead of being bundled by one aggregator, the total commission is materially lower — commonly around 3-5%, versus the 20-30% typical of Swiggy and Zomato.

- How you join: choose a seller app (seller-network-participant), onboard with your FSSAI, GST, PAN and bank details, load your catalogue, and decide on logistics. Popular seller apps reported in 2026 include Magicpin, uEngage and Mystore; buyer apps include Paytm, Magicpin and Pincode.
- Documents and timing: the same core set as the apps. Onboarding is typically 2-5 business days from complete documents to first order.
- The honest caveat: order volumes through ONDC are still lower than the established platforms and the experience varies by buyer app. Treat it as an additional channel alongside Swiggy and Zomato, not a replacement — a lower commission on few orders is worth less than a higher rate on many.

Also on the market in 2026

Swiggy and Zomato have both moved toward lower-commission budget formats (for example Swiggy's 'Toing'), and a zero-commission competitor, Rapido Ownly, has entered delivery in Bengaluru. The lesson is the same as with ONDC: build a channel mix, and do not let any single platform own your customer relationship.

25. Your own ordering channel — the biggest margin lever

Every rupee of order value that comes through your own WhatsApp link or website carries no commission. That is why a direct channel is the single most powerful margin lever available to a small kitchen: the same dish, the same customer, several percentage points more profit.

1. Give every repeat customer a direct ordering link — a WhatsApp number, a simple order form, or a payment link.
2. Reward direct ordering with something the app cannot offer — a free add-on, priority delivery, or a small loyalty credit.
3. Put the link on every box, every label and every app order's packaging slip, so app customers discover your cheaper channel.

4. Take payments by UPI (and a payment gateway for larger orders). Gateway fees are around 2% — far below an app commission.

Even shifting a quarter of your orders to the direct channel can move a kitchen from break-even to a healthy net margin. Build the habit from day one, not after the app has trained all your customers to order through it.

26. Photography and the first-order experience

On an app, your photograph is your shopfront. A clear, well-lit, honest picture of the actual dish converts far better than a stock image, and it reduces complaints because the customer gets what they saw. Invest a modest amount here — a few thousand rupees in decent food photography pays back in conversion and ratings.

Then protect the first order. Hot food, correct items, clean packaging, on-time delivery: do these consistently and your rating climbs above 4.2, which is where app visibility and repeat orders begin. One bad first experience costs you the customer and the review; a great one earns a repeat customer and a referral.

PART 7

Operations

Running the kitchen without losing the margin

27. The daily kitchen rhythm

Consistency is what separates a kitchen that survives from one that burns out. Build a simple daily rhythm and follow it.

- Morning: confirm the day's orders and subscriptions, generate a prep list from confirmed numbers (not from memory), and check stock against the plan.
- Batch where you can: cook staples in batches to cut gas and labour per dish, but cook fast-moving items close to the delivery window so they arrive fresh.
- Pack to a standard: same portions, same seals, same labels, every time. Standard packing is what keeps ratings stable when you are busy.
- Close the day with a five-minute tally: orders served, dishes that ran out or were wasted, and any complaint. This single habit catches problems while they are still small.

28. Delivery: yourself, or a partner?

In the beginning, delivering yourself is usually cheapest and gives you control over how the food arrives. As volume grows, you have three choices: hire a delivery person, use the platform's delivery network, or use a third-party logistics provider (for example the logistics partners used on ONDC).

Option	Best when	Watch out for
Self-delivery	Small volume, dense route, you want full control	Caps your order count; you cannot cook and deliver at once
Own delivery staff	Steady daily volume on a known route	Fixed wage cost even on slow days
Platform delivery network	You want reach without hiring	Cost is bundled into your platform economics
Third-party logistics (e.g. on ONDC)	You are selling on ONDC or your own site	You must integrate it — the biggest operational overhead for new joiners

Keep your delivery radius tight — around 5 km is a common sweet spot. Food arrives hot, logistics stay cheap, and long-distance surcharges (which sit disproportionately on cloud kitchens) stay off your statement.

29. Ratings, refunds and cancellations

On the apps, your rating is your marketing budget. Protect it deliberately.

- Treat every complaint as a data point, not an insult. Note the cause — late, cold, wrong item, portion — and fix the process, not just the one order.
- Watch refunds and cancellations. Refund deductions come straight out of your payout; a pattern of them signals a packing or prep problem.
- Never argue with a customer in the app chat. Resolve quickly and keep it professional; the review is public and permanent.
- Aim to hold your rating above 4.2. Below roughly 4.0, app visibility and order volume can fall sharply.

30. The weekly reconciliation habit

A cloud kitchen never sees cash over a counter — it sees only the platform's net payout, after commission, ads, discounts and refunds. Without a weekly reconciliation you cannot tell whether the platform charged the agreed commission, whether cancelled orders were compensated, or what your real margin per order actually was.

1. Every week, match your bank credits against your platform dashboard, order by order or at least day by day.
2. Check the commission rate actually applied against your contract.
3. List every discount you funded and add it to your true cost of each order.
4. Update the unit-economics sheet (Part 9) with the real numbers, not the ones you assumed.

This is a business control, not a tax formality. Operators who reconcile weekly catch margin leaks in days; operators who do not find out at the end of the quarter, when the money is already gone.

PART 8

The 30-day launch plan

Week by week, from today to first order

This grid assumes the smallest sensible start — a home tiffin service or a shared-kitchen slot — and can be compressed or stretched to fit your situation. If you are going straight to a standalone kitchen, add the lease and fit-out weeks before Week 1.

Week 1 — Decide and register

- Choose your model (Part 2) and write down the startup budget you can afford without borrowing at credit-card rates.
- Apply for FSSAI on FoSCoS. This is the gate for everything else, so start it first.
- Check your GST position with your accountant and begin registration if you will list on an app.
- Cost 12-20 dishes on paper (Part 5) and set your subscription and delivery prices.

Week 2 — Build the basics

- Set up your kitchen: vessels, tiffin boxes, insulated bags, an extra burner if needed.
- Finalise a 7-day rotating menu and your pause/skip rules in writing.
- Set up your WhatsApp business number, a simple menu image, and a payment link (UPI).
- Buy packaging and print labels with your FSSAI number and veg/non-veg marks.

Week 3 — Prove the food

- Launch a trial meal to one dense cluster — an apartment complex, PG, hostel or office block.
- Ask every taster for one honest piece of feedback and act on it.
- Push the weekly menu to local WhatsApp groups and your status daily.
- Start the first-30-customers tracker (Part 9).

Week 4 — Add the channels

- Once FSSAI (and GST, if needed) are in hand, begin Swiggy and Zomato onboarding and ONDC seller-app onboarding in parallel.
- Prepare dish photographs and a launch-ready menu for the apps.
- Set your delivery radius and operating hours; keep the radius tight.
- Put your direct-ordering link on every box and label from the first app order.

What success looks like at day 30

FSSAI (and GST, if applicable) in hand; at least one app listing live or in verification; 20-30 paying subscription customers; and a costed menu where every dish is profitable after a 30-35% deduction. That is a real business — not a finished one, but a real one.

PART 9

Templates & worksheets

The sheets you will actually use

Print these, or copy them into a spreadsheet. Fill them in with real numbers, not guesses — that is the whole point.

32. Startup cost estimator

Fill in your own numbers (Rs.)

FSSAI registration / licence fee ..... _____

GST registration (if applicable) ..... _____

Trade licence / Shops & Establishment ..... _____

Fire NOC / health trade licence (if needed) .. _____

Space: rent + deposit (shared or standalone) .. _____

Equipment and kitchen fit-out ..... _____

Packaging (initial stock) ..... _____

First-stock raw material ..... _____

Branding, photography, listing ..... _____

Working-capital buffer (15-30 days) ..... _____

TOTAL STARTUP COST ..... _____

Money you can spend without borrowing at 36%+ .. _____

Gap (if the total is higher than the last line) .. _____ ← close this gap before you start

33. Per-dish costing sheet

One row per dish

Dish name ..... _____

Ingredients (exact portion cost) ..... _____

Gas / fuel allowance ..... _____

Packaging (container + seal + label + cutlery) ... _____

Labour share ..... _____

DISH COST (subtotal) ..... _____

Target margin (30-50%) ..... _____

SUGGESTED SELLING PRICE ..... _____

Price on app (cost ÷ 0.67, to clear ~33%) ..... _____

Price in your area (what customers already pay) .. _____

Verdict: profitable / reprice / remove ..... _____

34. Monthly unit-economics sheet

Fill in from your real statements each month

Total orders ..... _____

Average order value (AOV) ..... _____

Gross order value (orders × AOV) ..... _____

Less: commission paid ..... _____

Less: GST on commission ..... _____

Less: payment / collection fees ..... _____

Less: discounts you funded ..... _____

Net platform payout ..... _____

Less: food cost ..... _____

Less: packaging ..... _____

Less: rent / slot rent ..... _____

Less: staff wages ..... _____

Less: gas, power, water ..... _____

Less: ads / marketing ..... _____

NET PROFIT ..... _____

Share of orders from your direct channel (%) ..... _____

35. First-30-customers tracker and WhatsApp scripts

Tracker columns

Name | Cluster / building | Plan (1 or 2 meals) | Start date | Monthly value | Direct or app | Notes / feedback

Running total of customers: ____ · Target: 30 · Monthly recurring revenue so far: Rs. ____

Copy-paste WhatsApp messages (edit the blanks):

- New-menu broadcast: "Namaste! Here is this week's home-tiffin menu (Mon-Sun) with prices and the monthly plan. Reply 'MENU' and I'll send the photo. Fresh, home-cooked, delivered on time."
- Trial offer: "First meal at Rs. ___ for new customers this week. Tell me your building and I'll add you to the route."
- Referral ask: "If you enjoyed the food, one introduction to a neighbour who eats lunch away from home would mean a lot. I have a small thank-you for you both."
- Direct-channel nudge: "Order directly on this link and get a free add-on — same food, delivered by us, and it helps me keep prices honest."
- Pause / skip reply: "No problem — your plan is paused for those days and added back at the end. Thanks for telling me in advance."

PART 10

Mistakes & FAQ

What goes wrong, and the straight answers

36. The twelve mistakes that kill Indian kitchens

1. Signing a big lease and buying full equipment before proving anyone will pay for the food.
2. Setting prices that cannot survive a 30-35% commission — and finding out only at month-end.
3. Opting into every app discount campaign without checking what you are funding.
4. Running an 85-item menu that carries stock, wastage and slow prep.
5. Skipping FSSAI or guessing the wrong tier, then losing weeks to onboarding rejections.
6. A business name or address that does not match across FSSAI, GST, PAN and bank — the classic onboarding delay.
7. No direct ordering channel, so every order pays commission forever.
8. No working capital buffer, so a slow fortnight becomes a rent crisis.
9. Ignoring the weekly reconciliation, so a wrong commission or an unrecovered refund goes unnoticed.
10. Chasing volume with heavy app ads before the unit economics are positive.
11. Letting the rating slip below about 4.0 and losing app visibility.
12. Treating a subscription business casually — no pause/skip rules, no menu rotation, and surprised cancellations.

37. Twenty questions, answered straight

Can I really start a food business from my home kitchen?

Yes, but it must be registered. Any food business selling to the public in India, including a home tiffin service, needs FSSAI registration through the FoSCoS portal. Home cooks are not exempt once they sell commercially.

Which FSSAI tier do I need?

For turnover up to Rs. 1.5 crore (the threshold from 1 April 2026), the Basic Registration at about Rs. 100 a year is generally the starting point. Above that, a State Licence; above Rs. 50 crore, a Central Licence. Some aggregators insist on a State Licence for meat, poultry, seafood or dairy-heavy menus.

Do I need to renew my FSSAI licence?

No renewal cycle — registrations and licences issued from 1 April 2026 have perpetual validity. But the annual fee must still be paid, or the licence is treated as suspended.

Do I need GST?

Most standalone restaurants and cloud kitchens charge 5% GST without input tax credit. If you list on Swiggy or Zomato, the widely held view is that GST registration becomes mandatory regardless of turnover under section 24(ix). Confirm your position with an accountant.

Who pays GST on app orders?

The platform, under section 9(5) of the CGST Act, since 1 January 2022. You still report those orders in your returns and count them in your turnover.

What commission will Swiggy or Zomato charge me?
There is no published rate card. Commission commonly runs 18-28% and the all-in effective take can reach 25-35% once GST, payment fees and funded discounts are added. Your contract and settlement statement are the only binding source.

Is the Rs. 17.58 platform fee my cost?
No. It is charged to the diner at checkout and is not deducted from your settlement. It still matters indirectly because it raises the customer's bill.

What is the cheapest way to get app reach?
A shared or cloud-kitchen slot — you rent a station inside a licensed facility and use its compliance records to list, for a fraction of a standalone kitchen's setup.

How much can a home tiffin earn?
With about 30 customers on a Rs. 3,000-a-month plan, revenue is roughly Rs. 90,000 a month; after food, packaging, delivery and expenses, net commonly lands around Rs. 20,000-30,000.

What should I charge for a tiffin?
Metro meals commonly sit at Rs. 70-120; monthly plans at Rs. 2,500-4,000 for one meal a day. Price from your dish cost plus a 40-50% gross margin, then compare with local rates.

Why is my app price higher than my normal price?
Because the commission, GST on commission, payment fee and any discount you fund come out of the order. Successful operators price the delivery menu about 15-25% higher to absorb the take.

How many orders a day to break even?
A well-run kitchen usually needs 40-60 orders a day at an average order value of Rs. 250-350, often reached over 6-12 months. Kitchens stuck below about 30 orders a day for long are the ones that close.

What is ONDC, in one line?
A government-backed open network where the buyer app, seller app and logistics are separate participants, so the total commission is far lower than a single aggregator's — commonly around 3-5%.

Is ONDC a replacement for Swiggy and Zomato?
Not today. Volumes are lower and the experience varies by buyer app. Use it as an additional channel alongside the established platforms.

What is the single biggest margin lever?
Your own direct ordering channel. Every order placed through your WhatsApp link or website carries no commission.

What licences beyond FSSAI and GST do I need?
Commonly a municipal trade licence, Shops & Establishment registration, and a Fire NOC where you use commercial gas. Some states also require a health trade licence. Confirm locally.

How long does onboarding take?
Typically about 3-7 working days for Swiggy and 2-5 for Zomato once documents are complete, assuming no name or address mismatches. ONDC onboarding is usually 2-5 business days.

Should I register with both apps?
Usually yes. The marginal effort of the second listing is small once documents are ready, and the order split between the two is often not what you expect.

How do I protect my rating?
Hot food, correct items, clean leak-proof packaging and on-time delivery, every time. Aim to stay above 4.2; below about 4.0 app visibility can fall sharply.

What is the most common reason new kitchens fail?
Cash, not cooking — signing a lease or buying equipment before proving demand, and running out of working capital. Prove the food with the cheapest channel first, then reinvest.

38. Sources and verification notes

This playbook was compiled and fact-checked in October 2026 against official and current sources. Because fees, commission rates and thresholds change, always confirm the current position before you act.

- FSSAI: Food Safety and Standards (Licensing and Registration of Food Businesses) Amendment Regulations, 2026 (Gazette notification dated 10 March 2026); FSSAI order dated 13 March 2026 revising turnover thresholds effective 1 April 2026; FSSAI FAQs dated 27 March 2026; the FoSCoS portal (foscos.fssai.gov.in).
- GST: CBIC/CGST Act provisions — section 9(5) (e-commerce operator as supplier of restaurant service, effective 1 January 2022), section 24(ix) (compulsory registration for e-commerce supply), the 5% restaurant rate without ITC, and the GST 2.0 changes effective 22 September 2025.
- Platforms: Swiggy and Zomato partner onboarding pages and published partner policies; reported 2026 commission ranges and the March 2026 platform-fee change (Rs. 17.58 per order, GST-inclusive). Commission is set per outlet by contract and is not published as an official rate card.
- ONDC: the Open Network for Digital Commerce protocol documentation and 2026 seller guides (seller apps, buyer apps, logistics roles, commission ranges).
- Market and cost data: current 2026 industry research and operator-reported cost and margin bands. Where sources disagree, this book presents a range rather than a single figure.

Thank you for buying this playbook. If it helped you start — or fix — your kitchen, that is exactly what it was built to do. For questions, write to lonefaisal977@gmail.com or message +91 96826 00301 on WhatsApp.